

CHAPTER 3

Subject–Verb Agreement & Articles

Agreement rules, countability, and article usage

Study • Practice • Review

Prepared as a structured learning handout

1. Learning Objectives

- Apply standard and more complex Subject–Verb Agreement rules consistently.
- Distinguish countable and non-count/uncountable nouns.
- Use the indefinite articles a/an and the definite article the appropriately.

2. Core Rules of Subject–Verb Agreement

A verb normally agrees with its subject in number (singular or plural) and person.

Rule	Explanation	Example
Basic singular	Singular subjects take singular verb forms.	The student studies diligently.
Basic plural	Plural subjects take the base verb form in the present tense.	The students study diligently.
Compound with and	Two subjects joined by <i><i>and</i></i> generally take a plural verb.	Ayush and Sita are working.
Or / nor	With different-number subjects, the verb commonly agrees with the nearer subject.	He was / The teachers were inside.
Collective nouns	Often singular when the group acts as one unit.	The team is winning.

3. Special Cases

A. Indefinite Pronouns

Commonly singular: everyone, everybody, someone, somebody, nobody, no one, anyone, anybody, each, every, either, neither.

Everyone **has** completed their registration form. • Each of the options **is** valid.

Commonly plural: both, few, many, several.

Several students **were** absent yesterday.

B. Uncountable & Mass Nouns

Nouns such as information, advice, knowledge, furniture, water, and news are normally treated as singular when used as uncountable nouns.

The news **was** surprising. • Furniture **is** expensive these days.

C. Phrases Between Subject and Verb

Do not let a prepositional phrase distract you from the true subject.

Incorrect: The quality of these mangoes **are** poor.
Correct: The **quality** of these mangoes **is** poor.

4. Articles: A, An, and The

Articles come before nouns and help show whether a noun is general/non-specific or specific.

Article	Main use	Example
a	Singular count noun before a consonant sound.	a book; a university; a European country
an	Singular count noun before a vowel sound.	an apple; an hour; an honest person
the	A specific or already identified noun; also used in several fixed contexts.	the Himalayas

Article	Main use	Example
Zero article (X)	Plural/uncountable nouns in a general sense and many proper names	Music is relaxing. He lives in Kathmandu.

A. Indefinite Articles: A / An

Choose based on **sound**, not simply the first written letter. “University” begins with a /j/ sound, so we say **a university**. “Umbrella” begins with a vowel sound, so we say **an umbrella**.

B. Definite Article: The

- **Second mention:** I bought a book yesterday. The book is informative.
- **Unique objects:** the sun, the moon, the internet, the equator.
- **Superlatives and ordinals:** the highest peak; the first chapter.
- **Some geographical names:** the Himalayas, the Nile, the United States.

C. Zero Article

- Plural or uncountable nouns used generally: I love music.
- Proper names of people, cities, and most countries: He lives in Kathmandu.
- Academic subjects and languages: She studies Computer Science in English.

5. Practice Exercises

A. Choose the correct verb:

- 1 Neither the manager nor the employees (was / were) present at the meeting.
- 2 The list of successful candidates (has / have) been posted on the notice board.
- 3 One hundred rupees (is / are) not a large amount of money.
- 4 Mathematics (is / are) my favorite subject in school.
- 5 Bread and butter (is / are) a wholesome breakfast.

B. Insert a, an, the, or X:

- 1 Maya wants to learn how to play _____ guitar.
- 2 He holds _____ Master’s degree in Data Science.
- 3 _____ honesty is considered _____ best policy.
- 4 We watched _____ interesting documentary about _____ Himalayas last night.
- 5 _____ milk is good for human health.

6. Chapter Test

- 1 Correct the agreement error: “Each of the boys have brought their own textbook.”
- 2 Explain why we write “a university” but “an umbrella.”
- 3 Complete: “The committee _____ (disagree / disagrees) on the new policy proposal.”
- 4 Insert the article: “She is _____ most intelligent student in our batch.”
- 5 True or False: Uncountable nouns like information and knowledge take plural verbs when describing large amounts.

7. Answer Key

Practice A: 1. were 2. has 3. is 4. is 5. is.

Practice B: 1. the 2. a 3. X; the 4. an; the 5. X.

Test: 1. “Each of the boys **has** brought...” because each is singular. 2. University begins with a consonant /j/ sound; umbrella begins with a vowel sound. 3. disagrees. 4. the. 5. False—uncountable nouns normally take singular verbs.

Note: *Collective nouns can vary by meaning and variety of English. In standard learner English, use a singular verb when the group is treated as one unit.*